

ESSENTIAL

National Student Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - Zulassungsbescheid, Sperrkonto, insurance, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the National Student Visa is - and isn't

This is a national, long-stay visa (Type D) under the German Residence Act - a materially different legal basis from the Schengen Tourist Visa's shared EU Visa Code. It lets you enter Germany to study at a university or, if needed first, complete a Studienkolleg preparatory year. It is not itself your final residence status: you must apply for a residence permit (Aufenthaltserlaubnis) at your local Ausländerbehörde after arriving.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Get your Zulassungsbescheid	Admission from a German university, or conditional admission plus Studienkolleg enrolment.
2. Obtain an APS certificate, if required	For certain nationalities only - a separate academic credential verification process.
3. Set up your Sperrkonto	Or arrange an accepted alternative - see the Financial Requirements Overview.
4. Arrange health insurance	GKV (statutory) or private, depending on your circumstances.
5. Apply at your consulate	Submit your application and attend an appointment.
6. Decision and visa issuance	If approved, a visa sticker valid for entry and an initial period is affixed to your passport.
7. Register and get your residence permit	After arrival: Anmeldung (address registration), then apply for your Aufenthaltserlaubnis at the Ausländerbehörde.

APS certification

Applicants from certain countries (notably China, Vietnam, and in some cases India) need an Academic Evaluation Centre (Akademische Prüfstelle, APS) certificate verifying their academic credentials, obtained separately before applying for the visa. This isn't universal - check whether it applies to your specific nationality and situation.

Health insurance: the GKV/private distinction

Most students under 30 enrolling at a state-recognised German university are required to use statutory public health insurance (gesetzliche Krankenversicherung, GKV) - a distinctive dual system compared to countries with a single mandatory private-insurance requirement. Students over that age threshold, in certain programme types, or in other specific circumstances typically need private insurance instead. Confirm which applies to you directly with a German health insurer or your university's international office.

Work rights while studying

Non-EU students on this visa can generally work a limited number of days per year without needing separate permission - commonly framed as a certain number of full days or double that number of half days annually - alongside unlimited work as a student assistant (studentische Hilfskraft) at their own university. The specific day-count has been stable but can change, so confirm the current figure rather than relying on an old source.

Frequently asked questions

Is this the same as a Schengen visa?

No - it's a national long-stay visa under German law, not the shared Schengen Type C visa, even though it also lets you travel within the Schengen area during its validity.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for how Remonstrations and judicial review work for this route.